Lesson 1: Order of Adjectives

What is an Adjective?

- Adjectives are words that modify (describe) the qualities or states of being of nouns and pronouns: *enormous, silly, yellow, interesting, fast, etc.*

- They can also describe the quantity of nouns:

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many, few, millions, eleven, etc.

Before we address the proper order of adjectives, we need to recognize the difference between two types of adjectives:

- Cumulative
- Coordinate

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- **Cumulative adjectives** work together to modify a noun. They cumulate (or combine together) as they get nearer to the noun to create a more specific meaning.

- Cumulative adjectives ***must*** appear in a specific order.

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- They ***cannot*** be separated by commas or conjunctions (such as “and” or “but”).

It is ***not*** fixed, there are variations of the order.

Placement	Type of Adjective	Examples
1	Determiner or Article	• a, an, the
2	Quantity	• one, three, etc.

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3	Opinion	• beautiful, smart, etc.
4	Size	• big, small, etc.

Placement	Type of Adjective	Examples
5	Physical Quality	• thin, lumpy, etc.
6	Shape	• square, round, etc.

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7	Age	• young, old, etc.
8	Color	• red, purple, etc.

Placement	Type of Adjective	Examples
9	Origin or Religion	• French, Catholic, etc.
10	Material	• metal, leather, etc.

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11	Type	• two-sided, allpurpose, etc.
12	Purpose	• *cutting* knife, *driving* gloves, etc.

- When you use multiple adjectives from different categories as we indicated, they function as **cumulative adjectives**. You do not need to put commas between cumulative adjectives.

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- *A large antique Chinese porcelain vase…*
- *The angry furry dog…*
- If you used several adjectives from the same category, they are **coordinate adjectives**. Then you need to use commas between coordinate adjectives, but the order that you use them *usually* does not matter.

- *A dull, meaningless afternoon…*

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- *The mean and angry dog…*

Sentence position affects adjective order:

- *It was a **loud**, **crowded** concert.*

Can be rewritten as:

- *The concert was **loud** and **crowded**.*

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When the last word in the phrase, clause, or sentence is an adjective, it needs to follow “and”.

The Oxford comma: if you have three or more adjectives, comma placement before the second-to-last adjective depends on your style of writing.

- *Their house is **cramped**, **cold**, and **modern**.*

Or can be rewritten as:

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- *Their house is **cramped, cold** and **modern.***

In some situations, omitting the oxford comma can sometimes cause misunderstandings.

Example:

I love my parents, Lady Gaga and Ultraman. •

"Your parents are Lady Gaga and Ultraman??"

Rewritten as:

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I love my parents, Lady Gaga, and Ultraman. -

or-

I love: my parents, Lady Gaga, and Ultraman.

- **Caution:** Too many adjectives can be confusing to readers and listeners.

- Try to focus on only two or three meaningful adjectives that will add relevant description to

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your sentence. Then place them in the proper order.